20 Italian kitchen hacks

I trucchi della nonna

Small habits from Italian home kitchens that save time, money and flavour. Pin it inside a cupboard door.

The hacks

1. **Keep the pasta water.** Its starch turns cheese and oil into a creamy sauce. Save a mugful before draining.
2. **Salt the water, not the sauce.** Pasta water should taste lightly of the sea; season the sauce at the end.
3. **Freeze Parmigiano rinds.** Drop one into soups and stews for a deep savoury flavour; remove before serving.
4. **Revive stale bread.** Turn it into panzanella, ribollita, pappa al pomodoro or breadcrumbs.
5. **Peel garlic with a knife.** Press the clove with the flat of the blade and the skin slips off.
6. **Grate tomatoes.** Rub a halved tomato on a box grater for an instant fresh sauce; the skin stays behind.
7. **Rest meat and risotto.** Two minutes off the heat lets juices settle and risotto turn creamy.
8. **Toast nuts in a dry pan.** Pine nuts for pesto taste twice as nutty after a minute in a hot pan.
9. **Finish pasta in the pan.** Drain it a minute early and finish cooking it in the sauce with a splash of water.
10. **Never rinse pasta.** Rinsing washes off the starch that helps the sauce cling.
11. **Soak beans overnight.** They cook faster and more evenly; change the water before cooking.
12. **Keep basil like flowers.** Stand the stems in a glass of water at room temperature, not in the fridge.
13. **Tear basil, don’t chop it.** Tearing bruises it less, so it stays green.
14. **Use the whole herb.** Parsley stalks add flavour to stock and soffritto.
15. **Cook soffritto slowly.** Ten gentle minutes for onion, carrot and celery builds the flavour of the whole dish.
16. **Season risotto stock.** Taste the stock first: risotto can only be as good as its stock.
17. **Freeze leftover wine.** In an ice-cube tray, ready for the next risotto or ragù.
18. **Squeeze lemons at room temperature.** Roll them on the worktop first and you get more juice.
19. **Plan leftovers.** Cook extra risotto for arancini, extra pasta for a frittata di pasta.
20. **Taste as you go.** Nonna never measured salt: she tasted, adjusted and tasted again.